but violent peasant insurrection'[1] in the 1960s, Naxalism has spread across the central 'forest belt' in several states, including West Bengal, Bihar, Odisha, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand and Andhra Pradesh. However, no state has been as significantly affected as Chhattisgarh. The modus operandi of the movement ranged from sabotage of security forces and assassination of those with alternative viewpoints to attacks on state institutions and public services.

In this environment, Salwa Judum ('purification hunt' in Gondi, a language spoken by Adivasis in central India) was established as a counter-insurgency movement in Chhattisgarh in 2005. Led by Congress leader Mahendra Karma, it was an armed civilian movement comprising thousands of Adivasis. The state maintained that Salwa Judum was a spontaneous uprising against the violence inflicted by the Naxalites. However, it was widely acknowledged as an 'officially sponsored civil war'[2] in which the state armed untrained Adivasis, many of them children, with weapons such as guns, axes, lathis, bows and arrows.

Salwa Judum had a thin veneer of legal sanction, as some of its members (including children) were appointed as 'special police officers' (SPOs) by the state. SPOs included not just some members of Salwa Judum, but also Adivasis, Dalits and some former Naxalites who had switched loyalties. As the name suggests, SPOs are meant to be appointed in special situations to tackle unlawful assemblies, riots or disturbances that the ordinary police is unable to contain on its own strength. They have the same powers, and are subject to the same duties, as ordinary police officers. The law contemplated that they be appointed to handle temporary situations, not long-term insurgencies.

Salwa Judum developed an ignominious reputation in a short span of time. Entire villages in Naxal-affected regions were burnt to the ground by the militia, with their residents shifted to 'relief camps'. Adivasis who were thought to sympathize with the Naxals were presumed guilty and killed without a semblance of due process. Incidents of rape were not uncommon. A newspaper report published less than a year after Salwa Judum's formation quoted Mahendra Karma as observing: 'Unless you cut off the